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Don Alias

Don Alias was born on December 25, 1939 in New York City. He briefly pursued a career in biochemistry but his love for percussion led him to music full time by the early 1960's. Don has played drum set and congas with a lengthy list of jazz and popular artists, including Miles Davis, Blood, Sweat & Tears, David Sanborn and Paul Simon. He continues to tour and record and has set the highest standards for aspiring percussionists.

Don was interviewed in New York City on January 6, 2002 by Monk Rowe, director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in New York City filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have Don Alias, percussionist extraordinaire, with me.

DA: That's some nice words you've got. Thank you.

MR: I'm glad I got it out.

DA: Well I appreciate doing this and anything to further the cause of my instrument and music, I'll do that anytime, sure.

MR: You know, before we were rolling you were saying how the role of the percussionist wasn't always really respected or wanted?

DA: Yeah. True facts. I mean just from my experience, you know, I've had a very, very wonderful career, and never thought about being a musician. I went to school for something else you know. But I remember just going in places to sit in, you know you'd sit in you know. I went away to school, and I was playing in New York but when I went away to school that was taboo for moms. Moms did not want to know anything about being a musician. And so I would go and sit in and go in some of these clubs, and they'd see me carrying that conga drum, and I'd venture to say that most of the drummers, they kind of like looked down upon it. And one of the reasons why I think is because a lot of conga drummers, especially back in that time, the music was jazz, four-four swing. But since the music got really syncopated now, you know, there's plenty of room for conga drummers. But back then you know the drummer would always be kind of like locked in with a percussionist because he'd be playing the same thing over and over, and they didn't like that too well.

MR: When you say back then, what are the years you're talking about?

DA: I'm talking about like sixties. Like the sixties. Let me even pinpoint it more for you. I started my career seriously around '67, '68, so I guess that would be like a post Bebop era. But people were still swinging. And there was some conga drum usage in the Rhythm & Blues area, you know, Curtis Mayfield, you know if you listen to the

soundtrack of "Superfly," and you know you'll hear some conga drums and stuff in there. And there were some people that would use conga drums. And the funny thing about it is that usually you'd see them with one or two conga drums, instead of bongos. Not with paraphernalia that you see now. Guys will come with chimes and all kinds of stuff you know, banging on stuff. But back when the music was more swinging, I'm talking about jazz, improvisatory music was more four-four, it was a challenge to play that kind of music.

MR: What brought you to the conga drum?

DA: You know I don't know. Again, I never really thought about me being a professional musician. You know I went to school and studied medicine. You know my mom wanted me to be a doctor. And I went to a certain point and got my degree in biochemistry, but I got bit. I got bit seriously. I really — literally how it happened is that I had this wonderful job working in a research laboratory, cancer, up in Rhode Island, in hematology, it was a great laboratory. And I was also playing at night in Boston. So this trip back and forth, living in Providence and back to Boston, back and forth, and one day I walked into that laboratory and I sat down and I was dead tired, and I sat down and said what is the thing that makes you the happiest? Come on now. What is it that really makes you happy for a length of time? And I chose to play music. And how I got to it, the earliest I could remember was I had a little small drum and I have no idea where I got it from, I can't remember, with a Chinese design on it. So I used to call it a Chinese drum. A Chinese design. And I used to start banging on that.

MR: Was your household musical at all?

DA: Yeah, matter of fact my uncle played organ and keyboard, he was a swinging organ player. He lived in Washington and he used to play some jobs over there. My mom played a little piano. My grandmother played a little violin. Nothing serious. And they actually did make an attempt to send me and my brother to music lessons, piano. But at that period of time I wanted to be out playing basketball and stuff. I didn't want to be associated, you know. But every once in a while I would sneak in there, because we did have a piano, sneak in there and play some stuff. And the funny thing, people ask me about the background and stuff, my parents were born in the Caribbean. That's where my origins are from, like the specific island of St. Martin. And we grew up in a household that was like loaded with Calypso music. Not Reggae, not any other kind, it was Calypso music. And the only example I can think of is Harry Belafonte, you know with "Matilda" and all that kind of stuff. But we had the real hard core Calypso, the stuff that you couldn't get, that my parents brought along. And we liked to dance and so forth and so on. And this Calypso music of course it had that beat, you know it had that beat to it, and

I guess I got, somehow or another, snuck through the cracks to get to that feeling. But in my household, I grew up in a Calypso kind of environment.

MR: What did your parents do for a living?

DA: Mom was a supervisor at Harlem Hospital, which was like right down the street. Grandmom was a head caterer in the kitchen. And the one thing I can always remember about that is around Thanksgiving and Christmas we'd get this phone call and she'd be working and she'd say "come now" and we'd run over there and she'd have like — because they were going to throw it away anyway, all this surplus food — so she just dumped all of this stuff on us and I can always remember Thanksgiving and Christmas we had a lot of food because of her. And my dad, he separated and divorced like early on when we were young, my dad also worked, as a matter of fact also worked as a chef in a place called Horn and Hardart, I don't know if you know that chain — it was a chain of cafeterias.

MR: What was it called?

DA: Horn and Hardart. And it's like really, I don't think they're in business anymore. And he worked as a chef there. He was not musically inclined. He liked it but —

MR: Well I'm wondering what the phone call to your mother was like when you decided to switch careers.

DA: Hell. That's the only thing, for want of a better word. Take into consideration the time. It was the sixties, the fifties and sixties. I'm a black American growing up in a certain kind of environment and the revolution wasn't really going on when I was going to school, I'm talking about '58, '59. It wasn't really prevalent then. There were no revolutionary activities around that time. Parents wanted their kids — I'm talking about Afro-American parents — wanted their kids to be doctors, lawyers, something with some kind of clout to it, intellectually, you know, clout to it. Stuff like that. And needless to say when I told her that I had quit my laboratory job she didn't like that. As a matter of fact it was only recently, when I say recently I'm talking about maybe seven years maybe, that she — I think she liked more the people I was playing with than the playing. I said "Mom I'm playing with Miles Davis." "Oh Miles Davis." "Lou Rawls." "Oh Lou Rawls, oh." She would love all of that. But me being a musician, no she didn't want that. She was really upset about that.

MR: Gosh well she can at least brag to her neighbors perhaps.

DA: She did that. She did do that. Because I'd be there on a number of occasions when she'd turn around — "oh he played with —" moms, you know. But she would never of course give me the credit. That's all right, I accept it.

MR: When you were in Boston you were playing with guys like Chick Corea.

DA: Yes.

MR: And Alan Dawson. Did you have a defined goal at that time? Like I want to be — I'm not saying this very well, but like — a star in music. Was that a goal or was it just kind of—

DA: No. Never. Never. You know I'm focused in a certain way in terms of let me do the best that I can on this thing. Not what am I going to get from it, endorsements or whatever. Just let me do the best I can and then whatever comes will come. I never — and I don't know if that was a help or a hindrance — I never really really was ambitious about a career you know. It was just play your ass off and do the best you can. And somehow or another that worked. The ambition came with the playing. I mean all of a sudden you find yourself playing with Miles Davis, I'm not going to think about — man I'm playing with him I may get a record deal out of this. You know what I mean? Let me just do the best I can.

MR: Okay. Let's talk about him for a moment. I know you played on "Bitches Brew." Was that the first session you did with him?

DA: Yes.

MR: That must have been an experience.

DA: I'm telling you, you know we could go on, we could be sitting here for three or four hours to tell you about the feelings about that. I got this call from Tony Williams and we were playing a circuit, a George Wein, you know, who you are familiar with, the concerts. We were playing this circuit where on the bill would be Miles Davis and Nina Simone, and along with some other people like Blood, Sweat & Tears or some other people. And Miles would go on and then we would come. And on more than one occasion I would be playing, I played drums on that job with Nina Simone and also some percussion. I'd be playing and I'd turn around and he'd be standing there looking, just kind of looking around. And I'm like oh my goodness, you know. Then I had heard later on that Nina Simone was backstage saying things like "he'd better not steal my drummer, he'd better not steal my drummer." Anyway Tony Williams gave me the call to do this record date. And I walked into the studio — what a line up. I mean how can you go wrong? Whatever it is that he's doing, you can't go wrong with that. He had some of the best musicians in the world there. And the impact of it actually didn't really hit me and some of the other guys until the album itself came out and we really looked at the cover. That's such a dynamite cover. It is such a dynamite cover. I mean just the whole package you know, especially for that time, you know, there's some African stuff and there's some psychedelic stuff and then all kinds of stuff. And then that's when it kind of like, especially me, it's like man this is like — the optimum word here is innovation. This stuff is going to change the face of music, especially for Miles. Because again, everybody wanted to, a number of people I heard say that "My Funny Valentine," "Round About Midnight," wanted him to stick to that, nothing wrong with that. But as we all know

Miles was an innovator. But he will change the course of his playing and music, every, like I don't know, two or three years.

MR: Yeah. It's interesting, it's like just when the audience, at least some of them, would catch up with them, he'd be on to something else.

DA: On to something else. A lot of people didn't like "Bitches Brew." The real kind of like young crowd — that turned the corner crowd — the Jimi Hendrix people, you know, really liked that album. Because it was, again for want of a better word, psychedelic. The beats were different and the music was soulful and the young folks really liked that. Because that period of time, Jimi Hendrix and this huge musical revolution, with Donovan and all of these people, who by the way I would listen to too. I mean I was a James Brown fan you know and stuff like that. But when I got to listen to The Beatles and Donovan, I really got into that kind of music.

MR: At that session, was there anything on paper musically or was it pretty much—

DA: For us?

MR: Yeah.

DA: No. No. For us, no. And now I'm thinking about for the instrumentalists, Miles may have had some sketches, a little bit of this and that and this and that and this and that. But then again, the secret is his ability to hire musicians to do what he wants. That, I mean, that's what he had down to a tee, to hire the right guys. He always did it. I mean Herbie, you know, face it. He would always get the musicians that would do what he wanted to have done. So they may have had some sketches, like little things written out, but nothing formal, never anything formal. And the fact that I played drums on the record, I played drums on "Miles Runs the Voodoo Down" which is kind of like an inside, that's a very inside secret that a lot of people don't know about.

MR: Yeah it doesn't list that specifically.

DA: No. No it doesn't list it specifically. And it's really funny how it happened. You want to hear?

MR: Yeah.

DA: Well he had this tune, and "Miles Runs the Voodoo Down," and I was over there playing percussion and it was Lenny White and DeJohnette playing drums. The number one mistake I think is both of them had the Tony Williams-sounding drum set. What I mean by that, eighteen inch bass drum, you know tight sound, that Tony Williams sound. And both of them had drums tuned like that, and sounded like that. So you ain't going to get no contrast you know — pardon my English — you're not going to get contrast between the two drummers. They're going to sound alike. So Miles counts the tune off. It didn't happen. You've got to remember that the whole session up until that point was like one take. I don't even remember us doing two takes. Most of it was like one take. So things

were rustling — "I can't — stop playing," you know, in his voice. So he counts, he starts it off again. And Monk, he cut it off. So now everybody's getting just really nervous. Oh my goodness. With him, you know, if it ain't happening he knows right away, cut it off and he won't do it. You know what I mean? He'll just, you know. So he was getting ready to count it off again and I couldn't sit there any longer, because this specific piece of music I had a drum beat for this music that I had — I got it from a friend of mine in New Orleans. I actually got it from a friend of mine, Gene Perla, who got it from somebody in New Orleans, and it was one of those beats that was like right in, conducive for this kind of music. And I'm sitting there, you know, like this, like oh my God, I know this could work. But I'm — to step in and interrupt Miles Davis, it was kind of like a monumental thing to do you know. Believe me I was scared. And I'm just like "Miles, Miles, I've got this beat, I've got this beat man, I think it will be great." And he just kind of like looked over, and I was thinking that maybe he would utter some expletive to set me up. He looked over and he went "over there." So I sat down and we started playing and he shook his head and he went "show Jack." He wanted me to show Jack this rhythm. Now it's one of these rhythms that does not require any chops, does not require a whole bunch of paradiddles and ratamaques and all like that, it's something that you just work out.

MR: How does it go?

DA: Well I'll hum it to you and then, go listen to "Bitches Brew." It's [scats]. Please make sure that you do that because I want you to see the tune. And that started the record off, I mean that tune off, that particular tune. And I was trying to show Jack, again it was one of those rhythms that didn't require chops it just required some stuff, and it's not that he — matter of fact years later he had played it for me, he played the rhythm for me, and it's not that he couldn't have gotten it at that time but it was just it would have taken some time and Miles just went "stay there." So I got a chance to play drums, and that's like an inside thing. It's a little secret.

MR: Great story. Was Jack pissed?

DA: Not at all.

MR: That's good.

DA: Yeah. They'll tell you the story themselves. And let me just say this about that session. You've got all of these like, this sea of like monumental musicians, great musicians, there wasn't any time for egos. We do not go into a recording session with Miles Davis with an ego. You don't do that. He's the ego. You know what I mean? He's the guy. So there wasn't any room for that kind of stuff.

MR: Well over the years you've gotten calls from just a lengthy, lengthy list of people. As you look back on it, who stands out in your mind as maybe a really good learning experience?

DA: Ah, that's really a good one. You said a learning experience, that's a really great question to ask someone. Because that's what it's about. Elvin Jones. When I got the call to play with him we did a record, it's called "Merry Go Round," Chick Corea was on it. You know that record? That's a great record. And I got the call. And then I got a call to join his band. Now take into consideration this is Elvin Jones. I mean any musician who is watching this interview, I'm going to try to convey the feeling that I got playing with Elvin Jones. I mean he is an idol. Here is a guy that I would go and see with Trane. Here's a guy that changed the course of music. And when I say changed the course I mean there is like most of the drummers that are hitting it today, you'll hear a little bit of Elvin and Tony and guys. Here's a guy that would play a twenty minute chorus with John Coltrane, just him and Trane together. And I mean he was an idol. He was like Mr. Jones. So he asked me to play with him. So conga drums and Elvin, in that time. Now if you're the type of musician that's always thinking you're going to be coming down on one and so rigid that you're going to come down on one and be so rigid, uh uh. No way. So I'm thinking how I can play with Elvin Jones and still capture that — because I grew up, my roots were Afro-Cuban. So I'm thinking on how to drop this Afro-Cuban stuff, that cymbal, that ride cymbal with Elvin, and it worked out, yeah, it worked out. Now as you said the learning experience, there's a couple of stories I can tell you. We're playing Slugs. You ever hear of this club Slugs?

MR: Yeah, I've never been there, but—

DA: Well Slugs was your quintessential jazz club down on the East side, lower Third Street, somewhere around there. People laying out. You know. But it was a jazz club. Unfortunately it became infamous because Lee Morgan had gotten shot there. Anyway we're playing there and with really a great band of some young great musicians. Dave Liebman was in the band, and Steve Grossman was in the band, and Gene Perla and myself. They didn't have a keyboard player.

MR: No keyboard or guitar, right?

DA: No. No keyboard or guitar. I'll tell you a side story after that about the keyboard. So we're playing and believe me, this band was beginning to elevate off the ground. It was that strong. Well you know at the end of the gig we couldn't go to sleep because it was so up, you know what I mean, from the music, playing with Elvin, Elvin was playing his behind off, you know. I mean we'd go places, like we'd play the Village Vanguard and every drummer in the world would be sitting there you know, stuff like that. So during the course of the night Elvin broke something on his drums. So he went "hey Don," you know, "come over here and play some drums, man, while I fix this" — you see you're starting to laugh already — "while I fix this drum here." So in like three to four seconds my life flashed before me. I'm going to sit in playing Elvin Jones' drum set and playing –

so things are starting, I'm thinking about oh Jeez, he trusted me enough to want me to do it, you know, he must have heard that I had started to play drums, you know, up in the lofts in the jam sessions. You know he must have — yeah he trusted me. And then finally, the heck with it man, I'm going to — I can do this. I can do it. The challenge you know what I'm saying? And the guys that were in the band are guys that I'm living with too, in New York, so we're always jamming, we're very familiar with each other you know. In other words I can hold a medium swing four-four, I can do that. You know what I'm saying? Elvin comes up and calls out "Yesterdays" in the slowest — I have to laugh at this — the slowest tempo that you can think of. I mean [hums] and you know him, he's a brush master. Me and brushes were like oil and water. So we're starting off, I pick up these brushes and you could hear them getting caught in the side of the drums, you know, the noise, and it was quiet and you can hear things rattling around. And it was terrible. So at the end of it, and I won't use the word because we're on camera, but he said "Don you know something, you are a non-brush-playing — finish the sentence. And he was absolutely right. Absolutely right. And you are a non-brush-playing — and he's right. Which means get it together. So I mean to get the opportunity to even do that, and subsequently fail, you know, at doing it, and then for him to go hey — and all of those things that he's saying is like I'm sitting down, behind Elvin Jones playing a ballad with brushes. I got it together though.

MR: It's interesting he would pick that song and that tempo.

DA: Yeah.

MR: I wonder if he thought he was doing you a favor, or if he thought this is something you need to do.

DA: He could have been thinking about anything. He could have been thinking about — because I thought about it too, why did he call that tune. He could have been thinking about if this kid is going to play, let me challenge him, let's see where he's really at because this separates the men from the boys if you can play brushes on a ballad. Yeah, you know, let's see where he's at and stuff like that. And I kind of felt that that may have been the basis for why he called it, just to find out if I can do it.

MR: Well I think that's a skill that is somewhat overlooked often, being able to play slow—

DA: Of course, yeah.

MR: And the brushes.

DA: Play slow, I mean he counted that thing off. And he got me. And I'm glad he got me.

MR: You were going to tell me about the keyboard situation.

DA: Oh yeah. The band was on fire. If I can tell you, that band, I'm telling you, it was on fire. All of the young musicians would come down and see the band. Because he had a conga drummer. He had a conga drummer. That was one of the reason why it was like — and it

wasn't like a how do you say, a conga drummer like an African conga drummer where the music is flavored in an African way, you know like Kulu se Mama or something like that. It wasn't that kind of conga drumming. It was conga drumming to be able to play with four-four. To be able to sit down and play with Elvin. I mean he had some things, you know, "Recordame" he would do that was with a Latin flavor that was easy for us to get into. But to play with the four-four. And it was a challenge all the way. I think about it, it's like I'm so lucky. Because he also proved, he proved it to me too. I mean we're playing someplace in Milwaukee, I remember it being cold outside, and we're playing, it was a concert, and Elvin took this drum solo. Now because I'm a little bit shy I don't go over to guys and say oh man — I just don't do that, you know what I mean? But I had to like really give it up to him. Because I never in my life have ever seen anybody play drums like that. I mean I must have sounded like, you know, like a real naïve — Elvin, I never saw anybody play drums like that," and it was just like I was dumbfounded, the way he played. You know, sweat, all along the snare drum and everything. And he turned around and he said "that's all I want to do." Those are the exact words.

MR: Yeah, I saw him once. He sweat like Patrick Ewing sweats, oh man I'll tell you.

DA: That's exactly right.

MR: You know sometimes I feel sorry, physically I think of Gene Perla in that situation, you know that's physically a job.

DA: Oh yeah.

MR: To hold up the bass end of things.

DA: Well Gene, Gene of course was an excellent musician. Did you meet Gene? Do you know him?

MR: I have not met him yet.

DA: He is also an academic, you know he teaches someplace. And his goal, he had a goal because he was a musician, he went to Berklee, his goal was to play with Elvin Jones.

MR: There you go.

DA: Yeah. And believe me that's not an easy task if you are a bass — again if you are a musician or a bass player who thinks that you're going to come down on one. When he starts rolling around on those drums, and comes down, you have to really know what Elvin is playing and feel what he's playing.

MR: Did it help to watch him when you were playing?

DA: Oh yeah.

MR: So there was a visual part too.

DA: Definitely. Nobody — I didn't want anybody getting in the way of me being able to see him. Definitely. And then of course there would be periods of time when I just closed my eyes and floated into the music.

MR: Were there times, not just with him but with other people, where the percussionist would decide — being you — to not play, to just wait?

DA: Sure. Sure. Definitely. I'm trying to think of some instances, and again I go back to Miles and people like that, and to reiterate a phrase by Ahmad Jamal or where it came from I'm not sure but the phrase is "what you don't play is what's happening, the stuff that you don't play." And I had to think about that. I had to think about, you know, because that sound is a very prevalent sound. Conga drums. It's there, you know what I mean? I was doing an interview in Japan with a young drummer by the name of Gene Lake. Did you hear that name? Oliver Lake's son. And they were asking us, one question they asked us was what do you do, what do you look for when you go on the bandstand? What is it that you focus in on? And he says "well, you know, I listen to everybody and the music," which was a very intelligent answer. But I said "I want to get with the drummer and the bass player. That's where it is for me. Once we're cool, you know, then it's up to the rest of the guys. But let me get with that drummer and bass player and see what we're going to do. And then if we can lock in, the rest of the stuff is easy."

MR: Eventually you put your own ensembles together as a cooperative venture. What kind of step is that to take as far as trying to lead a group?

DA: Well I remember Tony Williams, I can always — I had such great teachers, and they would say like a couple of sentences and they would show you the road you know. Tony had this group called Ego that was out. And he was really like depressed and everything. And he just said "when you get your own band you never make any money." And there's a lot of people out there that knows what that means. First of all the Stone Alliance thing with Gene Perla, we were all, I'm telling you we were all just like close, crazy, wild friends. Friends. And we were up at my mother's house up near Mount Vernon and one of the reasons was to see if we could do something. And we sat down and we said let's start a band together. Now the great thing about this was that Gene, he is a quote a businessman unquote. And when I say that, I say that in reference to myself, I am not that way. I can not do that stuff. I can not sit down in front of a record company guy and try to push myself. I'm just not that kind of guy. But he is, you know, so he was the kind of guy that would get gigs and so forth and so on. I was designated the musical director, which was fine with me because I wanted that job. I wanted to be that in the band, although I did share with the guys. And Steve Grossman. So it was a trio. And what was the innovative thing about this trio, it was that it was a Rock 'n Roll-Jazz trio. That's a heck of a term. Sometimes the music got really loud and boisterous, but always swung, always had that element of improvisatory, pure jazz music. We'd do some four-four, but a lot of it was Funk tunes, Rhythm & Blues, and the music was designed to bring out the percussion. And the way I played drums, from playing conga drums, is I use a lot of tom

toms. So the music was designed to do all of that stuff. And we had relatively nice success. We did some albums over in South America and the last album we did with Kenny Kirkland, the late, great Kenny Kirkland, and some we did down in Rio, and we had some moderate success with that. But my friend Gene decided that he wanted to take some time off and raise a family and do things like that, so we had to disband then. Now I get people coming up to me saying "when are you going to start your own band, man?" And I look at them and I say "okay, okay" you know. My dream, and it did happen, it actually did happen, is for all the powers to be that are out there, like record company guys and that, I want them to knock on my door. I want them to ask me. Now that may sound like a monumental task to get people to ask you to make a record, but doggone it I want that. My dream came true a year and a half ago, where the Art Council of England called up, oh this was maybe two years ago, called up and said "we want to celebrate your many years of playing percussion. We want you to do some tours in England, about ten days. What kind of band would you like to have?" They should have never asked me that. I said I'm going for the jugular vein. What? I'm going for it.

MR: Well they asked.

DA: So I got — I asked for Mike Brecker, Randy Brecker, and three of the greatest percussionists, who I feel, in the world, because they have knowledge of the folklorico stuff and the contemporary stuff — Giovanni Hidalgo, Steve Barrios and Alex Acuna. I wanted Danilo Perez on piano but for some reason he couldn't make it so Gil Goldstein showed up. Carlos Benevent, who is the bass player for Paco DeLucia, the flamenco guitar player, and Mitch Stein on guitar, who was a friend of mine who I'd met playing with Tania Maria, and I really liked him so much and his playing so much I said well if I do anything big, man, you're coming with me. That's what happened. So I asked for all these guys. Six months later the guy called me up and said "you're on." So now I've got a band with the Brecker brothers, four of the greatest percussionists in the world, and this guy and this guy and all the different things. But you know something I wasn't worried one bit. I wasn't worried one bit. There were some bumps and unfortunately Gene Perla and myself, we had a little run in, it turned out that Carlos Benevent, because of his flamenco experience and because he was so adept at playing tempos and stuff like that, he was great for the band, and I wasn't afraid of anything because the music had been written for this set up. I mean old stuff, written like ten, fifteen years ago, finally was coming to fruition. We rehearsed two days, and I got to tell you that it was great. It was great. It was — you can hear it — because what happened, there were people like coming out of the woodwork now when they heard about this project, wanting to tape it, wanting to do a video, and I said no, man, I don't want these guys coming with cameras in my musicians' faces. And this rough thing. I don't want that. And some guy "okay well sit

over there, oh no we have to do this again." No. This is us. Let's do this, and so forth. And so there wasn't all of that. But they did burn some CD's live on the underground. And you can hear, like my rapport, I'm so excited. I was screaming and jumping up and down, I was so excited, I couldn't come down and I couldn't even talk. I have to remember that I'm supposed to also be an emcee for this thing. And I was saying stuff like "I'm in heaven, I've died, I'm going to heaven." I just couldn't help it. And those guys were great, they loved the tour, they wanted to do it again sometime soon. But look at that personnel. Now where am I going to get —

MR: I know. Amazing.

DA: Let me just say this, in terms of the money, all I can say is that that's really, when you think about who's in that band, and you think about the money, that's part of it. And of course they deserve it. So that dream came true. They asked me. And I gave it to them. I got great reviews, everybody was happy, and I could tell they were. So I gave it to them. Ask me, look, just ask me man. Just come and say listen, and the confidence I feel, I'm going to give it to you, it's really huge with me. So if some record company guy comes up and goes "what do you got?" I'm going to give it to him. Now I did approach some people and I don't — the look and the feeling I get is that this thing was so huge that they didn't know what to do. There were certain things in Mike Brecker's contract that he was only allowed to play some solos or one solo, some stuff like that. I got things like oh the solos are too long, or you won't get airplay. I'm going "man get outta here." So I'm in the process now of getting it to JVC and Sony.

MR: It seems to be the nature of the business these days that guys do so many different things that it's hard to have a band with the people that you really like, enough to make a payroll.

DA: Very difficult.

MR: You know to make it worth it for people to stay with one thing.

DA: I mean you can see the course of the way the music is going. You turn on what supposedly is a jazz station and they're not really playing contemporary improvisatory jazz. Improvisatory is a big word for me, because that's music that's coming off of the top of your head. And the way the music is going is disappointing in some ways to me, to hear. To hear your audience, your listening audience be so unsophisticated musically that they will ask for certain things and it hurts that people don't know who Coltrane is.

MR: Yeah. That it seems that their definition of jazz is going to end up being like the smooth jazz that — when I woke up this morning the alarm came on, it was smooth jazz.

DA: 101.9?

MR: Yeah. And I don't know. I don't like people to think of that music as what we think of as jazz.

DA: I don't either. That's why I was so happy with the London thing is because you know we had like 15 conga drums, all this stuff, and you would think, oh my God, cacophony, you know Sun Ra. Everybody's going to be playing at the same time — not that Sun Ra is bad, but I'm just saying, you know, it's going to be a mish mosh. But it wasn't like that.

MR: Are you able to define swing?

DA: No. No.

MR: Because earlier you had said, in your trio, that you would do swing but it would be Rock 'n Roll, but it always had something. What was that something?

DA: Feeling. It's really funny you know. And I run across this every once in a while when I'm in an environment where there's some heavy, heavy swingers, four-four swing type players, and some heavy syncopated Rhythm & Blues or Rock players. And how I feel on both of these environments you know. And I feel myself on the Swing going a certain way, and I feel myself going a certain way with that stuff. And feeling that it's all the same. It really is all the same. And I would like to see the guy define swing. I would like to listen in on that. You know technically, maybe a guy like Quincy or somebody could possibly do it and go back to where it came from, New Orleans and all of that stuff. But when I'm sitting in a place man and they're swinging, that's the most wonderful feeling in the world. You're a saxophone player.

MR: Wow. Over the years, the physical work that you do, has it ever had an impact on your body?

DA: On my health?

MR: Or does it keep you healthy?

DA: Not really. Coming up in this period of time there are few things, like I've got some herniated discs that talk to me every once in a while and say don't pick up that drum or you're going to feel this tomorrow. And again for me it's like give me the challenge. If I'm not feeling good, you know I wake up and something is sore or something, come on with it. It's like a fight to me. It's like not with violence or anything but it's like show it to me and let me do this you know, and then I'm going to get better. It's like Elvin never practices. I will use him as an example. He never practices. There are some guys who practice all the time who are excellent. I mean I don't want to take off more than two or three weeks. Because I've got a physical instrument. It's like staying in conditioning. It is a physical instrument. So you take off two or three weeks, it's just like any instrument, you're going to feel it. Put that horn in your mouth and something goes — yeah.

MR: I brought a couple of short excerpts of some of the things you've played on. And maybe you can place them.

[audio interlude]

DA: That's Jaco. That's Jaco Pastorius.

MR: This must have been some organization of musicians.

DA: Yeah, if I can go back to one of the questions that you asked me about the learning experience.

MR: Please.

DA: I ran down the business with Miles, but that guy there, that guy, I'm still in denial about thinking about him dead, because we were really close you know. Out of all of that crowd I was the first one to meet him. And Rick [Montalbano] will tell you all about this, I was doing a gig with Lou Rawls down in Florida and walked into, it was a television show, and we walked into the rehearsal place and all I heard was the bass. Not because it was loud, it's because I never heard nobody play like that. So I went over to him man and I says hey man, my name and so forth. And I guess he had heard, you know, "Bitches Brew" and so forth. And we became very close. And I'm in denial. I don't want to acknowledge that he's dead. Because we're looking at an innovator. We're looking at a force that also changed the course of — I mean the guy changed the course of bass players all over the world. Let's face it. And when a person can do that I'm with them. Change the course of bass playing, and his musicality, some of the music that he wrote was just incredible. The styles and stuff like that. And my learning experience from him was being in the company of a great musician. Being in that company. Of course Miles, you know all of them are great, but a great, young — let me put it that way — a young musician who was changing the course of music while it was happening. His first album was a killer you know, "Changes" was a monster. And all the subsequent stuff before he started to become mentally disturbed.

MR: Did he deny like help for that?

DA: Yeah, on a number of occasions he did. I suppose that, I mean I suppose anybody who was close to him had that opportunity to help him. Peter Erskine and all those guys that were really close to him — some of them went down to Florida to try to help him. But we played the Playboy Jazz Festival and it was Jaco's kind of like return to L.A. because he had been in Weather Report and that was like an L.A. kind of thing. So he had left Weather Report and now he's coming back to L.A. and the Playboy Jazz Festival. Prime time you know. Hugh Hefner, the whole, everybody was like wanting to know what he had gotten together. And the band was — we had done some touring and the band was killing. But Jaco unfortunately had been up for four days. And he wasn't right. He was just causing all kinds of riots backstage, just causing all kinds of things backstage, insulting people where he shouldn't have insulted, and we came on stage, he took his bass and threw it up in the air, turned around and said "take a conga drum solo." Jaco — this is not the place to do that, you know. Inviting all kinds of musicians that were not in

the band to come up and play. In other words he was gone. No question about it. And to see that go down was really painful, it was really a painful thing.

MR: More like some of the Rock 'n Roll people that you read about who self destruct.

DA: Yeah. He did that. It was almost like he was destined to go out early. You know he came, he was that spark that burned real bright and then disappeared. Now I'm like every time I meet anybody that's associated with any kind of Grammy thing I always drop that on them. I say when are you guys going to acknowledge Jaco Pastorius? You know we had a monumental concert for him at the Lone Star, you know Paul McCartney showed up and Sting showed up and those guys will tell you about Jaco. I mean why don't you have like a segment. You know it's not going to kill you to give him ten minutes or so to say here is a bass player before everybody forgets, here is a bass player that changed the course of music. Give it to him, man, come on.

MR: What was it about his sound? I mean aside from all the beautiful technical, amazing technical stuff he did it was like one note, he had this particular sound. Was there equipment behind that? Was there something about his bass or was it just him?

DA: You say was it just him? Was it his bass? I've got to say it's a combination of all of those. I remember in Osaka in Japan and Jaco threw his bass into the Osaka River. Them Japanese guys jumped in and got it. And Jaco thought that that was — he thought that that was a great act. He was like "oh man this cat jumped in the river and got my bass." And he thought that that was just like a spiritual thing. And he had that acoustic amp that he always used you know, and I suppose that had a great deal to do with the sound. That's the only piece of equipment that I ever saw him play was that Acoustic thing. And a combination of him and that made his sound. Incredible. I mean I didn't realize the impact that he would have on the music. Because we were just like kids playing in a pen or something you know. We were just like kids running around playing basketball and doing things. But then he'd sit down and play "Donna Lee" on the bass with conga drums. Brilliant, brilliant idea.

MR: Well thanks for sharing that. Really, I know you were pretty close to him.

DA: Yeah. It was hard. Him and Kenny Kirkland. I gave Kenny his first gig coming out of school, we played with Miroslav together. Another sweet person and a great musician. Those two guys really got inside me.

MR: You had a short stint with Weather Report too, didn't you?

DA: I remember playing live with Weather Report. That's another story if you don't mind. The very, very, very first album, the very first album, before "Heavy Weather," I mean the very first one with Miroslav and Al Mouzon were playing, I got called to come down and do a rehearsal with them. This was before that record, and that they were starting this new group called Weather Report. I was so broke, man, I'm telling you I was broke. I had

my conga drums I was holding the door and bringing the conga drums in, people were cursing at me, all kinds of terrible things, and I was broke. I had this carfare, I had to get down there. I went down there and Zawinul says "hey, man, we're traveling first class don't worry about a thing, this is going to be top notch." "Oh yeah, great." And at the end of it I said "how about some car fare to get home?" He said "oh no, we don't give advances right away." That was part of the problem. So anyway the next couple of days we go into the studio to record. And I have to honestly say I don't really care who sees what I'm saying here, this is the true fact, Zawinul got bossy and that's really a small word, he got controlling. That's a better word. He started to control everything. Now that's his prerogative. You know he's the leader and stuff like that. But man, don't take away from what we've got to give you. Now there was another percussionist on that gig. There was an Afro-American girl who was a legitimate percussionist. When I say legitimate I mean she was classically trained, tympanis, mallets, the whole thing. She was on that session. We got into a hassle with Zawinul. Zawinul did not put my name on that record.

MR: I'll be darned.

DA: And when it came out and I put it on, and I looked and that's me playing. There's a tune on there called I think "Time." I said that's me playing. So I called up Alphonze Mouzon and I said "what's the deal here, man?" And he says "yeah, yeah, yeah you're playing on it." I said "you didn't know that Zawinul did not put my name and he put Airto or somebody?" And he didn't know that. So we had this falling out for years. I didn't want to have nothing to do with that kind of thinking. Don't do that man. Don't ever do that. I don't care what kind of hassles that you've got with your musicians, you don't deprive them of being recognized for a piece of music. Don't do that. So time goes on and I'm playing with Blood, Sweat & Tears, and Jaco actually also was in Blood, Sweat & Tears, and I'm sitting in a hotel room in Dallas, Texas, and I get a call from Jaco. And he's saying "man, I'm going with Weather Report." He says "why don't you come on, man and we can do this." I thought about it for a minute and I said "well you know me and Joe had this big falling out you know." He said "I'll call you back in ten minutes." I got a call from Joe. Joe apologized for this whole thing. Now if you know Joe and you know his persona, he's a controlling type of guy. I'm not saying anything that people don't already know. So I said okay I'll join man, I'll join, no problem. I'm sitting there in an hour, suddenly it was really something. Just about an hour later the phone rings and it's Miles. You know? And this was like '75 or just before he had retired that long retirement. It's Miles. "Oh come on." Now this would be my second time coming back in the band after all the "Bitches Brew" stuff. I'd be going back in there a second time. And that was like, for me, a great honor, you know to come back and play. I had to call back, I mean there's

no choice. There's absolutely no choice. Not taking away from Zawinul, not taking away from anybody, but Miles Davis calls you — what are you going to do? So I called back Zawinul and I says "Joe I can't do it, Miles called and I can't, it's no choice." So he consequently went on to like put Miles down, "oh man, Miles' music man, my music is better." Granted, give him that prerogative too, you know, tell us about his music. But the end result, sorry Joe, there's no question about this, and hung up. And I went with Miles. Unfortunately Miles only did about five or six gigs after that because he was really sick, he was really sick and he retired after that. But that was the whole story with the Weather Report thing.

MR: Wow. I'm surprised that group lasted as long as it did.

DA: Weather Report?

MR: Yeah. With Zawinul and Wayne Shorter.

DA: They clashed.

MR: Yeah, I would imagine they would.

DA: Yeah Zawinul again had a certain controlling air about him, and I won't attribute that to any kind of like scene that he grew up in or anything, I'm just going to leave that alone. But he had a controlling thing about him and he wanted to be in charge and in control. And he had problems with Manola Badrena. You know that name? In Weather Report, or Heavy Weather rather. And would consequently get into a number of fights with these guys. So leave it alone. We're friends, that's all I care about.

MR: Right. Of the Pop people, sometimes it's hard to make a distinction but of the Pop artists you've worked with, who have you enjoyed the most?

DA: Joni Mitchell, great band. Dan Fogelberg. That's my only — oh no that's not the only one — I think "Bitches Brew" is but a platinum record, I got a platinum record for that one called "Innocent Age." And Ian Hunter — me and Jaco did him. English.

MR: Ian Hunter.

DA: Yeah, English guy, yeah, he made a record with me and Jaco. I think it's Ian Hunter.

MR: Was he in one of the Rock 'n Roll bands?

DA: Yeah, oh yeah.

MR: Gosh I can't remember it.

DA: Oh yeah he was back in then, back in the days. And of course Blood, Sweat & Tears. That was a wonderful experience because I started playing percussion and then moved over to the drum set. Bobby Columby, who had been doing it from the beginning, decided that he wanted to stay home I guess and collect the money. And I moved over to the drum chair, and for me that was a great challenge. Again, here comes the challenge. And the writers in the band were great, Larry Willis, Tony Klatka, they were great writers, they would write material for the band, jazz orientated but you know it had that

Blood, Sweat and Tears sound. So they also, if you consider them a Pop group, because they were very successful. I came in at the very tail end of the success you know. I was on salary. I didn't share in any of the revenues, shall we say, in the band.

MR: David Clayton Thomas was gone at that time, wasn't he?

DA: He had come back. When I came back in the band he had come back. He was a great singer for that type of stuff.

MR: He still sounds good.

DA: They're still going, right?

MR: They're still out there, yeah.

DA: Did you see them recently?

MR: Yes I have. One of my high school buddies is now like the music director, it's interesting.

DA: Really? What's his name?

MR: Steve Guttman. A trumpet player. Interesting. They sound good. They sound very close to the recordings. That's what they're about.

DA: I like that whole scene where an act or a musician can survive playing his old stuff. I like that. You know like Mangione? He's still — what is his tune?

MR: "Feels So Good?"

DA: "Feels So Good" and all that stuff.

MR: Yeah, and "Land of Make Believe."

DA: "Land of Make Believe." He's still surviving in that market, where people will come, they're older, forties and fifties, but still remember that scene, you know, because the seventies was a great time. And they would come through and they would see Chuck and he's still surviving off of that stuff. But surviving really good. Because he gets good musicians, and we get a chance to play.

MR: I saw Mick Jagger listed amongst — wait a minute, who haven't you played with? Louis Armstrong I guess.

DA: Oh I wish I could have done that. But Mick Jagger was really a funny scene. That was another funny scene. There was a producer there, Armenian or some kind of name that ended in I-A-N — something Franconian or I don't know, the only reason why I say that is because he was ethnically Far Eastern or something like that. But he was also a DJ in the clubs. He was producing this one tune. I don't know if you remember that Mick went to do a solo album. And I think something like love is in the title. I'm not sure, it's so long ago. And this producer called me up and he says "hey man he wants you to play percussion on this Mick Jagger record." You know, I'm going to feel good playing with Mick Jagger, you know, Miles Davis, like Mick Jagger gets the same amount of enthusiasm too you know because here is a Rock 'n Roll guy. So I brought every piece of percussion instrument that I could get my hands on. I brought the littlest shakers, I

brought big drums, small drums, I brought tambourines, I mean just a whole shitload of stuff, for want of a better word. And I mean the place was just jammed with drums and so forth. In other words, I wanted to be ready. Whatever this cat wanted, I'm going to give it to you. Whatever that you're looking for, I'm going to give that to you. Don't you — you know — turns out that Mick, all they wanted was for me to play on a Syndrum, drum fills. If you know how a Syndrum sounds it's that [scats]. So I sat there for six hours going [scats]. Six hours. Then the machine broke down. But if you ever get that record, I don't know it may be out of print or so, you listen to it you're going to hear that drum fill. You're going to hear [scats] and that's it.

MR: Were you saying to yourself man I wish they would have told me over the phone, here I am with my — your apartment must be something.

DA: Well actually no, I can't keep any stuff there. I keep it downtown. But I just wanted to be ready, you know, Mick Jagger. Who knows, maybe he may give me a gig or something. I mean what's his name is playing with Mick now — Darryl Jones. You know that bass player that played with Miles? He's playing — He's actually playing with the Rolling Stones.

MR: Right. I was out for a walk last night and I just happened to watch a guy, obviously he was going to a gig, pulling the car over, getting all the traps set, and stuff, and I'm thinking this must be a pain in New York City.

DA: Oh man, let me tell you man, I used to live in Providence, Rhode Island. And I would take that drum set and come down by Greyhound bus. And taxicab drivers, they don't want to know nothing about a bass player and a drummer. Get out of here with that stuff. Occasionally I would luck out and get a guy who would take my drums, but it was always a pain in the neck trying to carry the stuff around. A conga drum here, one conga drum, two conga drums. But it's really funny now, of course you now you acquire roadies along the way. And guys would say "oh man, you want to carry this, this stick bag?" And I'd go "no." And I said "I don't mean to sound like a spoiled brat, but listen man, I worked many years to not carry that stuff so please cut me some slack. I don't want to know anything about carrying anything.

MR: I earned it. That's great.

DA: You'd better believe it. In the snow, carrying conga drums.

MR: We'll wrap up here, but you had said way back in the beginning you were talking about when you started off and you had the other job in the laboratory and the Civil Rights really hadn't come in full swing yet. Have you noticed over the years a change in the relationship between the races in music?

DA: Sure. We've always had this standard as far as like jazz music is that that stuff is never going to enter in, you know, that prejudice stuff. We don't want no part of that. We're

jazz musicians and we love everybody. We love each other. Get that stuff out of here. Miles was a perfect example of that, as much as that he would want recognition for the Afro-American in terms of jazz music, he was not prejudiced. He didn't care anything about — I mean he got Bill Evans and all those guys in the band, Dave Hall. He didn't care anything about them. The change came about with the advent of certain kinds of music that told black people they were in charge of their own stuff, you know? Whoever didn't like it, too bad. But as you know the Afro-Americans have taken over the Rap scene. Some of it not to my liking. But over the course of time Afro-Americans have gotten into the music business with those people who had any kind of prejudices towards us, you're going to have to deal with it now baby. It's as simple as that. If you've got a sheet in your closet with eyes in it and a pointed — you know you're not going to have a good time. So I'm saying with the advent of us getting more into the business and controlling our own lives, great. But that's of course on the Pop level. The jazz level, humph. That's such a hard thing. Because you'll pick up a periodical or something and the general gist of it, what you'll get from it, it'll say "jazz is still alive, jazz is still alive, yeah, yeah." And then you'll look and you'll see Sweet Basil close. You know and then you go over and Europe will have this like kind of Montreaux festival. But in the Montreaux festivals you'll have like N Sync or — you know what I mean? Yeah. Have some kind of Pop act or something like that. It's hard, it's really hard to say about like the colored thing in terms of what the influence in the jazz thing is. And then you'll open up a "Down Beat" and you'll see all of these independent labels that have got all these people. I don't know half of these people who are playing. So, question, is jazz alive? Is jazz dead? Does jazz still have any political undertones to it where the Afro-American musicians are still crying "oh I can't get a break." Is all that stuff still happening? I suppose so. A little bit of it. If you want to stay true to your music, where does a jazz musician, what does he do?

MR: It's curious, sometimes it's like well if you want to be really respected don't make too much money. Because then the critics will say you sold out somehow.

DA: Sure. How many times have they done that? They did it to George Benson when he started to sing. And I say more power to it, because those guys do it good. It's the guys that don't do it good on 101.9 where it really does sound trite. You know they're selling out, when you hear all those trite melodies.

MR: Yeah, it's like there's that formula. You know the thing that I judge, as soon as that song is over, do you have any remembrance of that song?

DA: No. Not at all.

MR: Well I want to wrap up with — are we going to make it — a quote from a mutual friend.

DA: Lay it on me.

MR: He said about you, he said "he's one of the greatest people I've ever known, I learned more from him than any other musician I can think of."

DA: Oh man.

MR: From Rick Montalbano.

DA: Mmm, yeah, I can't handle this kind of stuff man. And vice versa. I learned, him being there during that period of time was like he saved my spirit. He saved my spirit, which at one particular time I didn't think was going to make it. But him being there, he's one guy that I would go to lengths to do anything for. I'll give you an example. If Rick called up now and said "hey man I need you up here," I'd go without even thinking about it.

MR: Glad to hear that. Well I learned a lot from him too actually. So I think in one respect, you must have taught me a few things through him.

DA: We had so much fun. You ought to let him tell you the fun that we used to have. Do you know the bass player Charles Frichtell?

MR: Yes, sure.

DA: Because when he came from playing with Chuck, when he came on the gig he says "Rick Montalbano told me—" I says "you know Rick Montalbano?" And he knew Rick too. Did you guys play together?

MR: Absolutely. A lot of times. Yup. And now I sub for him.

DA: For Charles Frichtell?

MR: No, no, no for Rick.

DA: Oh you play piano.

MR: Yeah. Well listen, this has really been absolutely fascinating. I want to thank you so much for sharing this time with me. It was everything I expected.

DA: I'll tell you man, you know, there's guys in this music business that are superstars and they do this kind of thing like a lot of times, you know, Sanborn and Herbie, I don't. I don't talk. I don't really talk. I don't have the opportunity to express myself like this. I can't tell you what it means to me.

MR: Excellent. It's been a great experience for me. All right?

DA: We made it, didn't we?